

주제

보이지 않는 것이 가진 힘의 근원은 어디인가?
홀단어 하나로 치환되지 않는 감각들은
어떻게 해석될 수 있는가?

내용

한국 사회를 움직이는 보이지 않는 기호들을
읽어본 적이 있는가?
사전적 정의 너머에 존재하는 사회적
조건들은 과연 어떤 방식으로 우리를
구성하고 있는가?

필요성

익숙했던 단어들을 정확히 설명할 수 있는가?
언어에 형태를 부여하는 이 기록은 결국
우리에게 어떤 실재감을 남기는가?

보이지 않는 것이 가진 힘의 근원은 어디인가?
홀단어 하나로 치환되지 않는 감각들은 어떻게
해석될 수 있는가?

언어에는 존재하지만 형태가 없는 것이 있습니다.
한국어에는 다른 언어로 직접 번역되지 않는 단어들이
있습니다. 눈치, 정(情), 한(恨), 체면, 빨리빨리.
이 단어들은 한국어 화자에게 실재하는 감각으로
기능하지만, 대응하는 외국어 단어가 존재하지 않으며,
가장 근접한 번역어를 선택하더라도 그 의미의 상당
부분이 번역의 과정에서 소실됩니다.
이 책은 그 소실되는 영역에 관한 기록입니다. 언어에는
존재하지만 형태가 없는 것에 시각적 형태를 부여하는
것, 이것이 이 작업의 주제¹입니다. 언어는 단순한 소통의
도구가 아닙니다. 언어는 한 사회가 어떤 경험을 공유
가능한 것으로 간주하며, 어떤 감각을 이름 붙일 만큼
반복적이고 실재하는 것으로 여기는지를 보여주는
구조적 기록²입니다. 특정 언어에만 존재하는 단어는 그
언어 공동체가 세대를 거쳐 명명해온 감각과 그 사회의
작동 방식을 압축적으로 담고 있습니다.

There exist things that live within language yet
possess no form. Korean contains words that
resist direct translation into other languages —
‘noonchi’, ‘jeong’, ‘han’, ‘chemyeon’, ‘bbaliballi’.
These words function as real and embodied
sensations for Korean speakers, yet no equivalent
foreign-language counterpart exists. Even the
closest approximation loses a significant portion of
its meaning in the act of translation. This book is a
record of what is lost in that gap. Giving visual form
to what exists in language but has no form — this
is the central theme of this work.
Language is not merely a tool for communication. It
is a structural record of how a society determines
which experiences are shareable, and which
sensations are considered recurrent and real
enough to be named. Words that exist only within
a particular language are a compressed archive of
the sensations that community has named across
generations, and of the social conditions under
which that language operates.

1
철학자 바바라 카생(Barbara Cassin)은 '번역
불가능한 것'을 번역할 수 없는 것이 아니라,
하나에서 다른 하나로 전이가 결코 끝나지 않는
것, 즉 끊임없는 번역의 시도를 촉발하는 것이라고
정의한다.

2
사피어-워프 가설(Sapir-Whorf Hypothesis)에
따르면, 개인이 사용하는 언어의 구조는 그가 세계를
인식하고 범주화하는 방식에 결정적인 영향을
미친다.

한국 사회를 움직이는 보이지 않는 기호들을
읽어본 적이 있는가?
사전적 정의 너머에 존재하는 사회적 조건들은
과연 어떤 방식으로 우리를 구성하고 있는가?

이 책에는 영어 단어 하나로 1:1 치환이 불가능한 한국어 단어 및 표현 75개가 수록되어 있습니다. 현재로서는 이 단어들이 존재하게 된 한국의 사회적 조건을 분석하여, 다음과 같은 네 가지 범주로 분류하는 체계를 고려하고 있습니다. 첫 번째 범주인 유교적 위계에서는 나이와 지위가 관계를 규정하는 구조 속의 단어들을(체면, 선후배, 끈대 등), 두 번째 정서의 축적과 억압에서는 내면에 쌓이는 감정들(한, 정, 서운하다 등)을 다루는 방안을 검토 중입니다. 또한 비언어적 소통을 다루는 집단적 감각 읽기¹(눈치, 우리 등), 그리고 근대화 이후의 긴장을 다루는 속도와 압박의 내면화(빨리빨리, 칼퇴 등) 등의 범주화를 통해 단어들의 사회적 맥락을 입체적으로 구성해보고자 합니다. 각 단어는 정의, 상황, 시각 이미지의 순서로 기록됩니다. 정의는 사전적 풀이를 넘어 그 단어가 어떤 사회적 조건 속에서 어떻게 기능하는지를 서술합니다. 상황은 그 단어가 실제로 발화되거나 체험되는 구체적 맥락을 제시합니다. 시각 이미지는 단어가 가리키는 감각을 시각적 형태로 번역한 이미지입니다. 언어적 서술이 닿지 못하는 지점에 이미지가 도달하기를 기대합니다.

This book contains 75 Korean words and expressions that resist direct 1:1 translation into English. Currently, I am exploring a classification system that organizes these entries into four potential categories based on the social conditions of their origin.

The first proposed category, Confucian Hierarchy, examines words emerging from structures where age and status define relationships. The second, Accumulation and Suppression of Emotion, considers words related to feelings that accrue internally. I am also considering categories such as Reading the Collective Sense, which deals with non-verbal communication, and Internalization of Speed and Pressure, reflecting tensions from rapid modernization. Through these frameworks, I aim to provide a multi-dimensional perspective on the social contexts of these words.

Each entry is documented in the following order: definition, context, and visual image. The definition describes how the word functions within its social conditions. The context presents the specific circumstances in which the word is experienced. The visual image translates the sensation into a visual form, reaching where language cannot.

익숙했던 단어들을 정확히 설명할 수 있는가?
언어에 형태를 부여하는 이 기록은 결국 우리에게
어떤 실재감을 남기는가?

한국 문화를 가시화하는 데 있어 한옥, 한식, 전통 색채와 같은 물질적·표면적 소재를 경유하는 방식은 이미 폭넓게 존재합니다. 이 프로젝트는 그러한 접근과 다른 경로를 제안합니다. 한국어라는 언어 자체가 담고 있는 구조로부터 한국 사회를 읽어내는 것입니다. 이 작업이 필요한 이유는 두 가지입니다. 첫째, 단어의 의미를 언어로만 풀어쓰는 것만으로는 전달에 한계가 있습니다. 특히 번역 불가능한 단어들은 정의문을 읽더라도 그 감각에 온전히 도달하기 어렵습니다. 이미지를 통해 그 단어의 감각에 접근하는 구조¹를 구축함으로써, 해당 언어를 모르는 사람도 그 단어들이 가리키는 경험에 도달할 수 있는 경로를 만들고자 합니다. 둘째, 이 작업은 한국어 화자 자신을 향한 것이기도 합니다. 당연하게 사용해온 단어들이 실은 어떤 사회적 조건 위에서 존재하는지를 낯설게 바라보는 기회²를 제공합니다. 내가 사용하는 언어, 내가 당연하게 여기는 위계 감각, 내가 설명 없이도 이해하는 감정들. 이 모든 것이 특정한 사회문화적 조건 속에서 형성된 것이라면, 그 단어들을 가시화하는 작업은 곧 나를 구성하는 조건들을 가시화하는 작업³이 됩니다. 이 책은 번역될 수 없는 것들에 대한 기록입니다. 언어에는 존재하지만 형태가 없는 것에 형태를 부여하려 했습니다.

Numerous existing approaches to visualizing Korean culture rely on material and surface-level elements. This project proposes a different path: reading Korean society from within the structure of the language itself.

There are two reasons this work is necessary. First, rendering meaning through language alone has inherent limitations. By constructing a framework in which the sensation of each word is approached through image, this project aims to create a pathway for those unfamiliar with the language to arrive at the experience each word describes.

Second, this work is also directed toward Korean speakers themselves. It offers an opportunity to look with fresh estrangement at words that have long been used without examination. If the language one uses and the hierarchical instincts one takes for granted were formed within specific sociocultural conditions, then the act of giving these words visible form is the act of making visible the conditions that constitute the self.

This book is a record of what cannot be translated. It is an attempt to give form to what exists in language but has no shape.

1
에드워드 홀(Edward T. Hall)의 분류에 따르면 한국은 전형적인 '고맥락 문화'에 해당하며, 이는 명시적 메시지보다 공유된 상황과 눈치가 정보 전달의 주된 채널임을 의미한다.

2
시각 언어는 추상적인 개념을 공감각적으로 구체화하며, 텍스트가 담지 못하는 정서적 여백과 동시적 이미지를 전달하는 보완적 매체로 기능한다.

3
빅토르 슈클로프스키(Viktor Shklovsky)가 제안한 '낯설게 하기(Ostranenie)'는 익숙하고 자동화된 대상을 예술적 수법을 통해 낯설게 함으로써 사물에 대한 지각을 회복시키는 과정이다.

4
자신이 사용하는 언어의 사회적 조건을 추적하는 행위는 미셸 푸코(Michel Foucault)가 말한 '자기의 기술(Technologies of the Self)'과 맥을 같이 하며, 이는 주체적인 자기 인식의 토대가 된다.

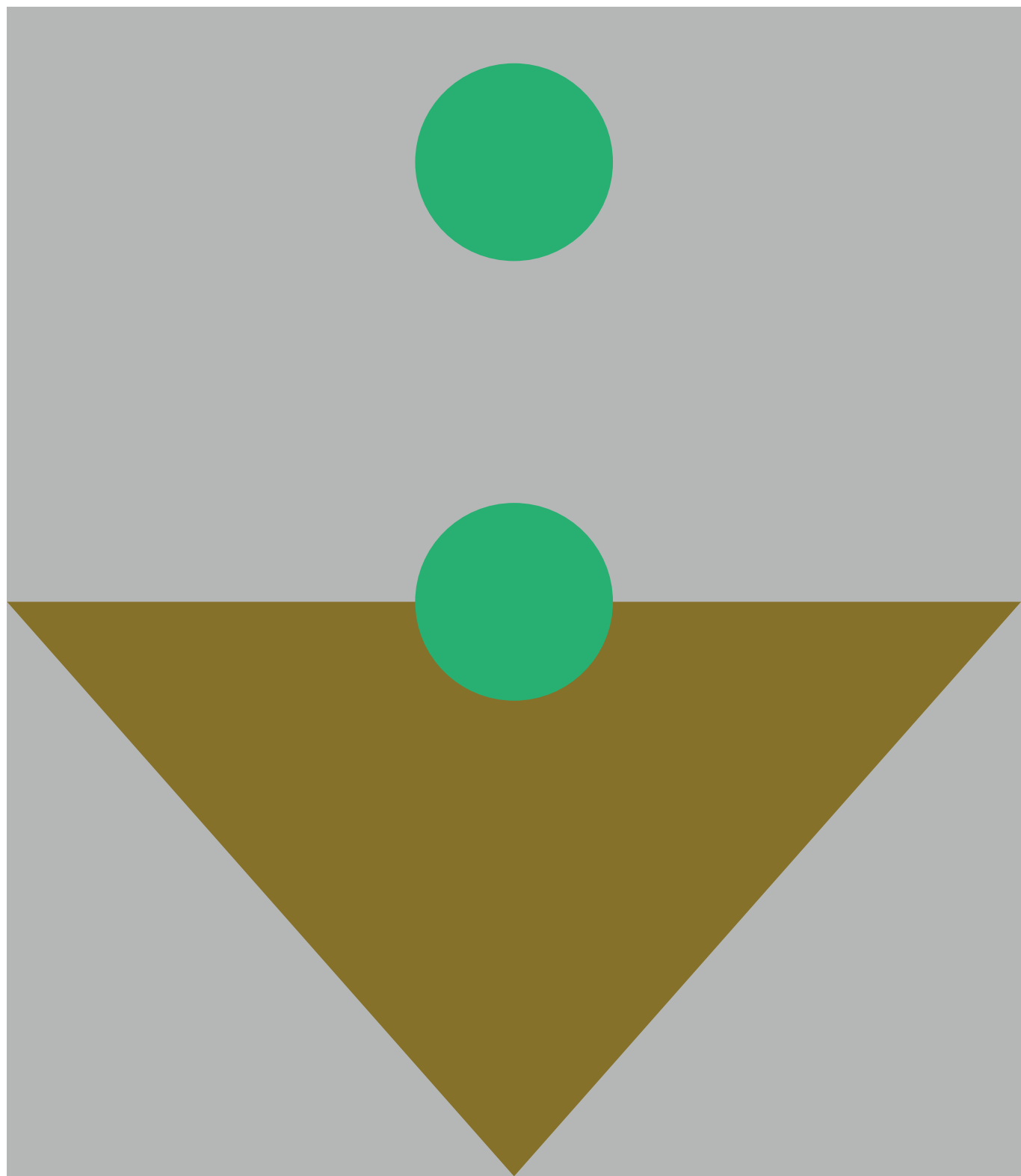
체면
Face, Dignity, Social Standing

- 1

English Approximation — Face, Dignity, Social Standing
- 2

Definitione — A form of social dignity or prestige maintained in the eyes of others; a complex concept that synthesizes one's moral reputation with strict adherence to outward formality and social decorum.
- 2

Contextual Usage — Providing an elaborate, expensive meal for guests even amidst severe financial hardship. "One must maintain their chemyeon; how could I possibly bring myself to say such a thing?"



「체면」, 2026
 Composition — Facing Two People
 English Approximation — Face, Dignity,
 Social Standing(Ostensible, Contrived)



「체면」, 2026
 Composition — Facing Two People
 English Approximation — Face, Dignity,
 Social Standing(Ostensible, Contrived)



『체면』, 2026
Composition — Facing Two People
English Approximation — Face, Dignity,
Social Standing(Ostensible, Contrived)

『체면』, 2026
Composition — Facing Two People
English Approximation — Face, Dignity,
Social Standing(Ostensible, Contrived)

울컥
Choked Up, Welling Up

- 1

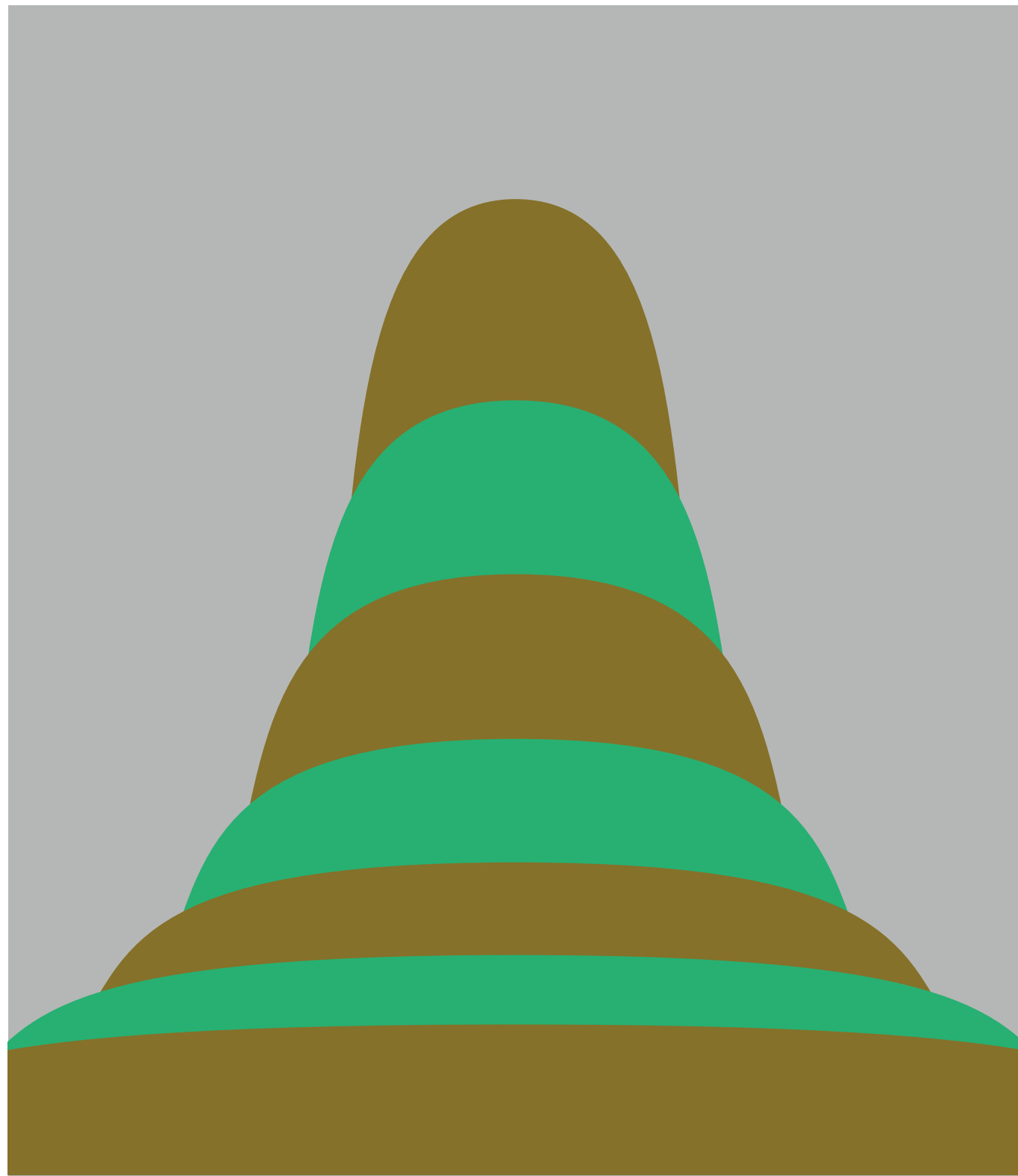
English Approximation — Choked Up, Welling Up
- 2

Definition — sudden, involuntary surge of emotion — often grief, gratitude, or tenderness — that rises in the chest and throat, threatening to overwhelm composure before one can suppress it.
- 2

Contextual Usage — Seeing her child receive the award after years of quiet struggle, she felt it rise without warning. "I wasn't expecting to ulkeok like that — I had to turn away so no one would notice."



'울컥', 2026
 Composition — Rapidly increasing
 English Approximation — Choked Up,
 Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
 positive and negative)



'울컥', 2026
 Composition — Rapidly increasing
 English Approximation — Choked Up,
 Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
 positive and negative)



「울컥」, 2026
 Composition — Rapidly increasing
 English Approximation — Choked Up,
 Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
 positive and negative)

「울컥」, 2026
 Composition — Rapidly increasing
 English Approximation — Choked Up,
 Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
 positive and negative)

끼리끼리

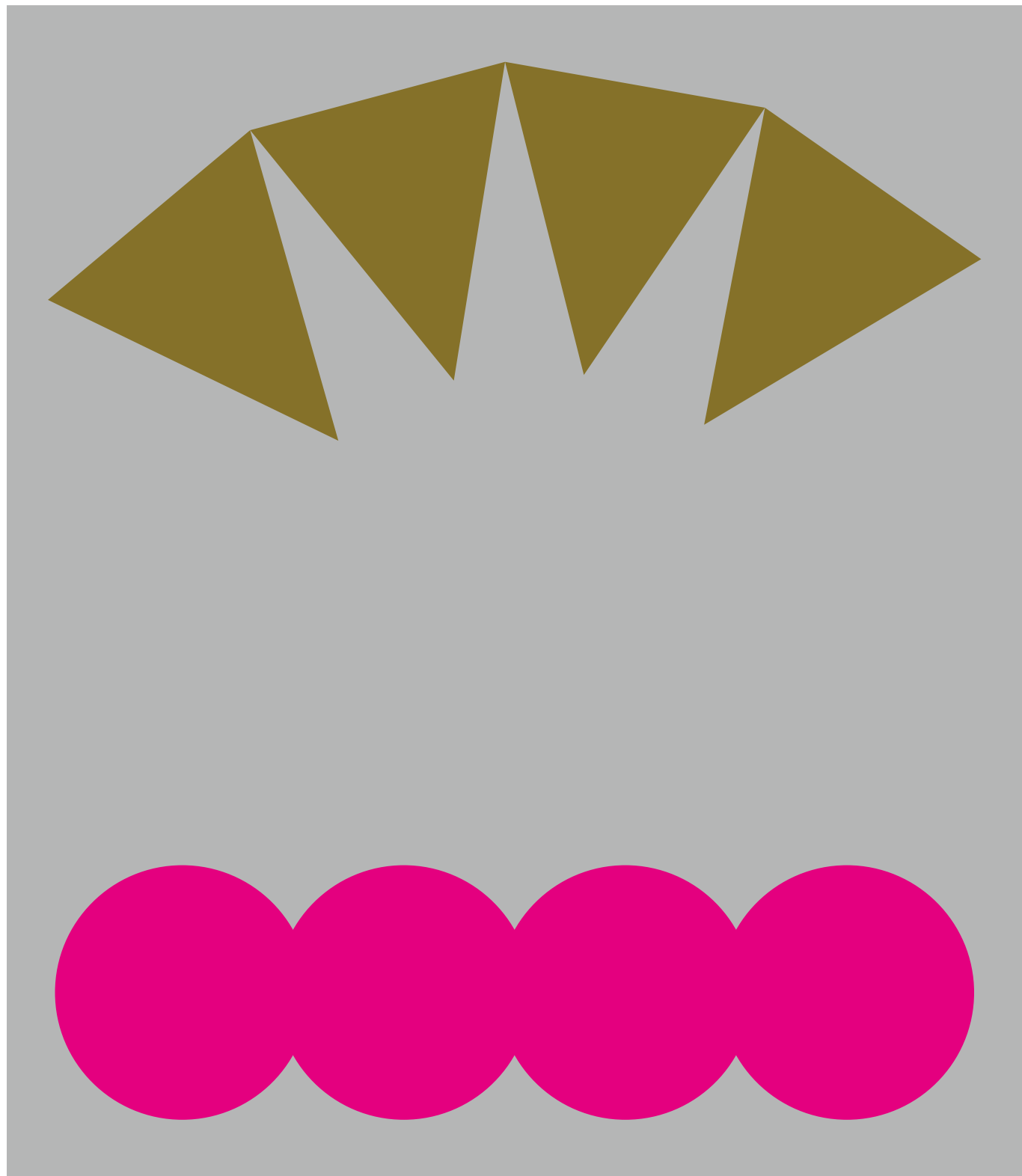
Birds of A feather, Cliquish

- 1

English Approximation — Birds of A feather, Cliquish
- 2

Definitione — The tendency of people to naturally gravitate toward and stick with those who are similar to themselves — in background, status, or sensibility — forming tight, often exclusive inner circles.
- 2

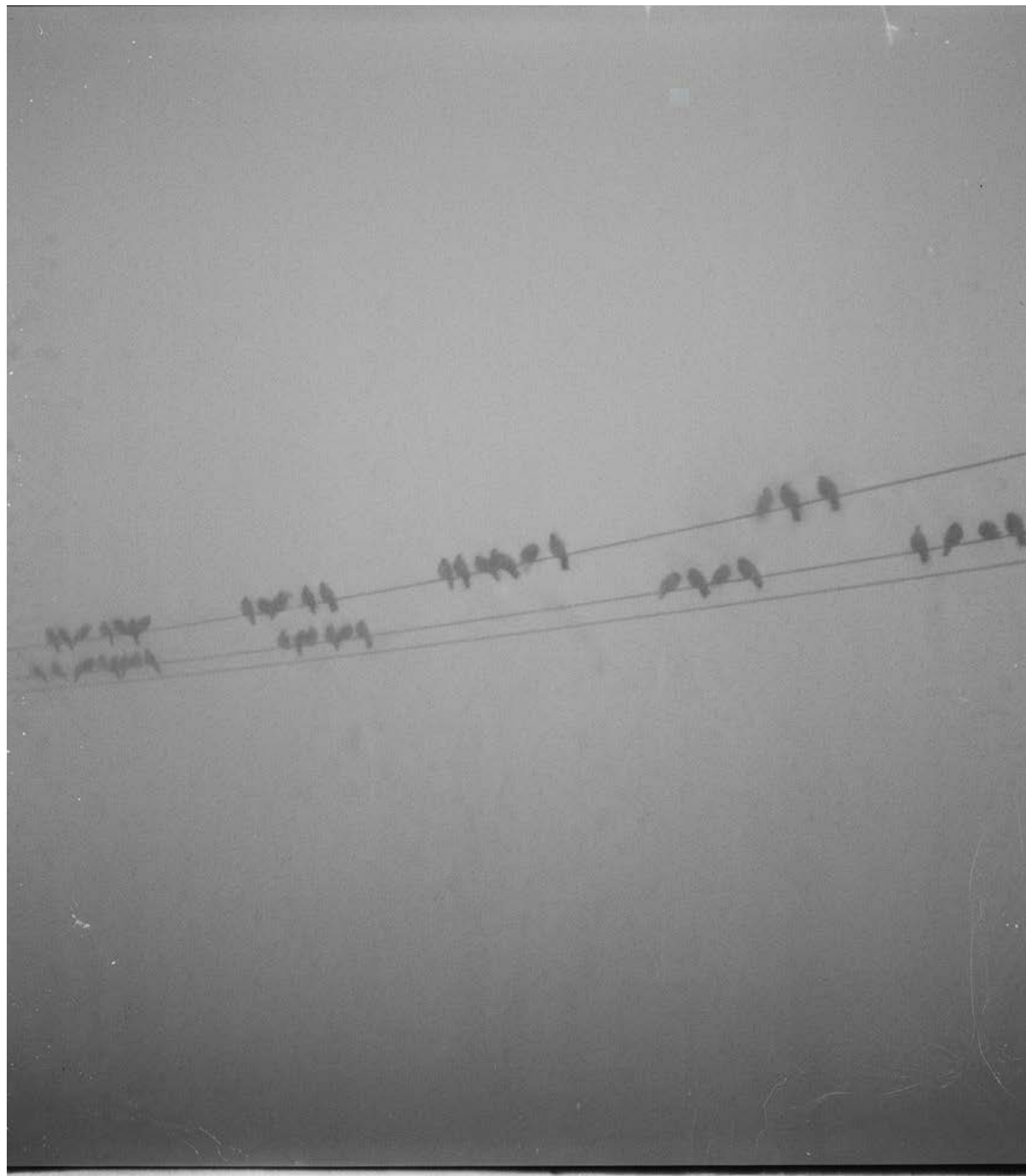
Contextual Usage — At every company dinner, the executives clustered together while the junior staff sat apart. "It's always kkirikkiri around here — you can tell exactly who belongs where just by where they sit."



「끼리끼리」, 2026
Composition — Rapidly increasing
English Approximation — Choked Up,
Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
positive and negative)



「끼리끼리」, 2026
Composition — Rapidly increasing
English Approximation — Choked Up,
Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
positive and negative)



『끼리끼리』, 2026
Composition — Rapidly increasing
English Approximation — Choked Up,
Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
positive and negative)

『끼리끼리』, 2026
Composition — Rapidly increasing
English Approximation — Choked Up,
Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
positive and negative)

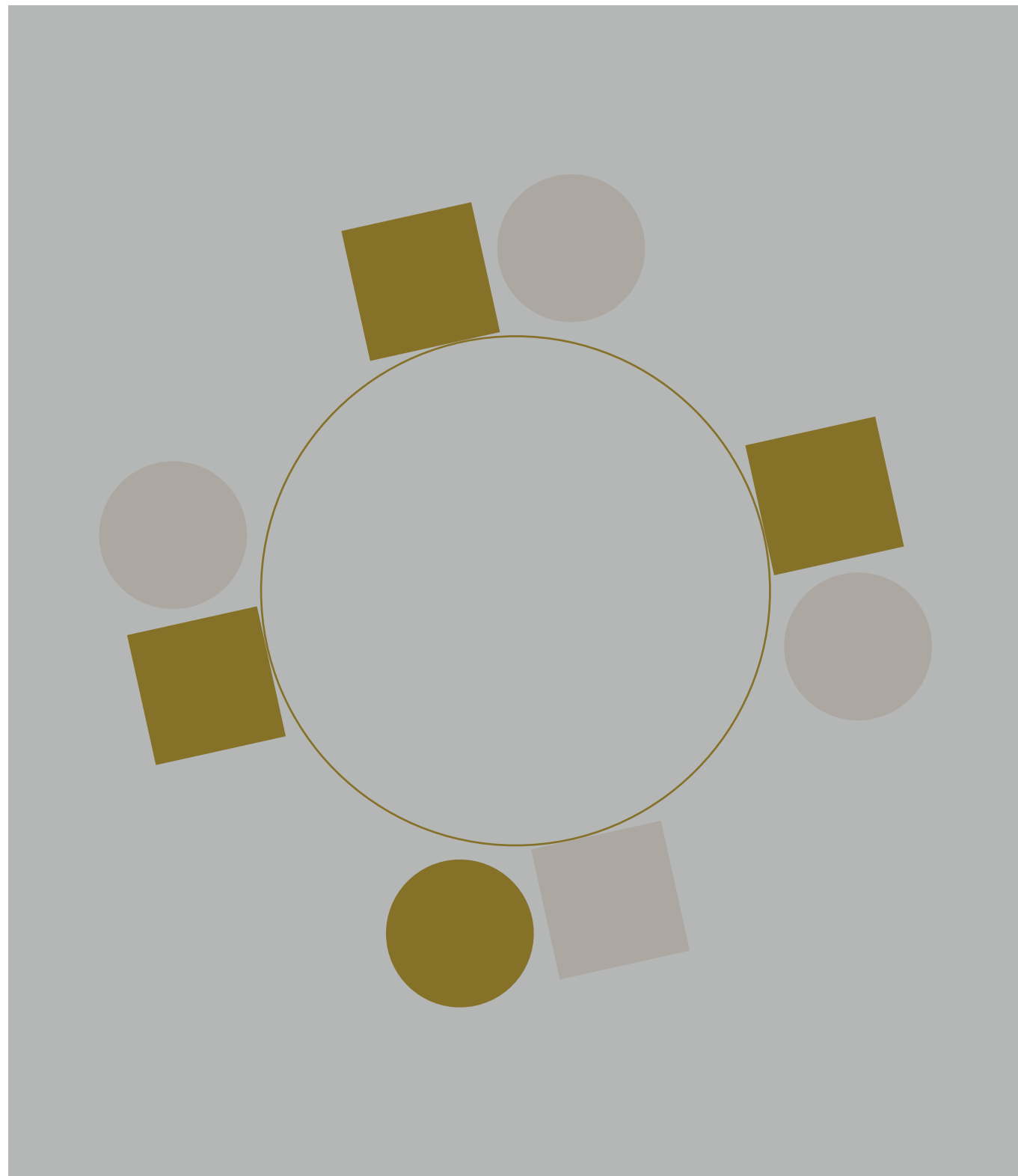
눈치

Social Awareness, Reading the room

1	2	2
English Approximation — Social Awareness, Reading the room	Definitione — The subtle, almost instinctive ability to read unspoken cues in a social situation — sensing the mood, power dynamics, and what is expected of you — and adjusting your behavior accordingly, without anyone having to say a word.	Contextual Usage — He kept talking loudly even as everyone grew quiet and uncomfortable. "That man has no nunchi whatsoever — couldn't he tell it was time to stop?"



「눈치」, 2026
 Composition — Rapidly increasing
 English Approximation — Choked Up,
 Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
 positive and negative)



「눈치」, 2026
 Composition — Rapidly increasing
 English Approximation — Choked Up,
 Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
 positive and negative)



「눈치」, 2026
Composition — Rapidly increasing
English Approximation — Choked Up,
Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
positive and negative)

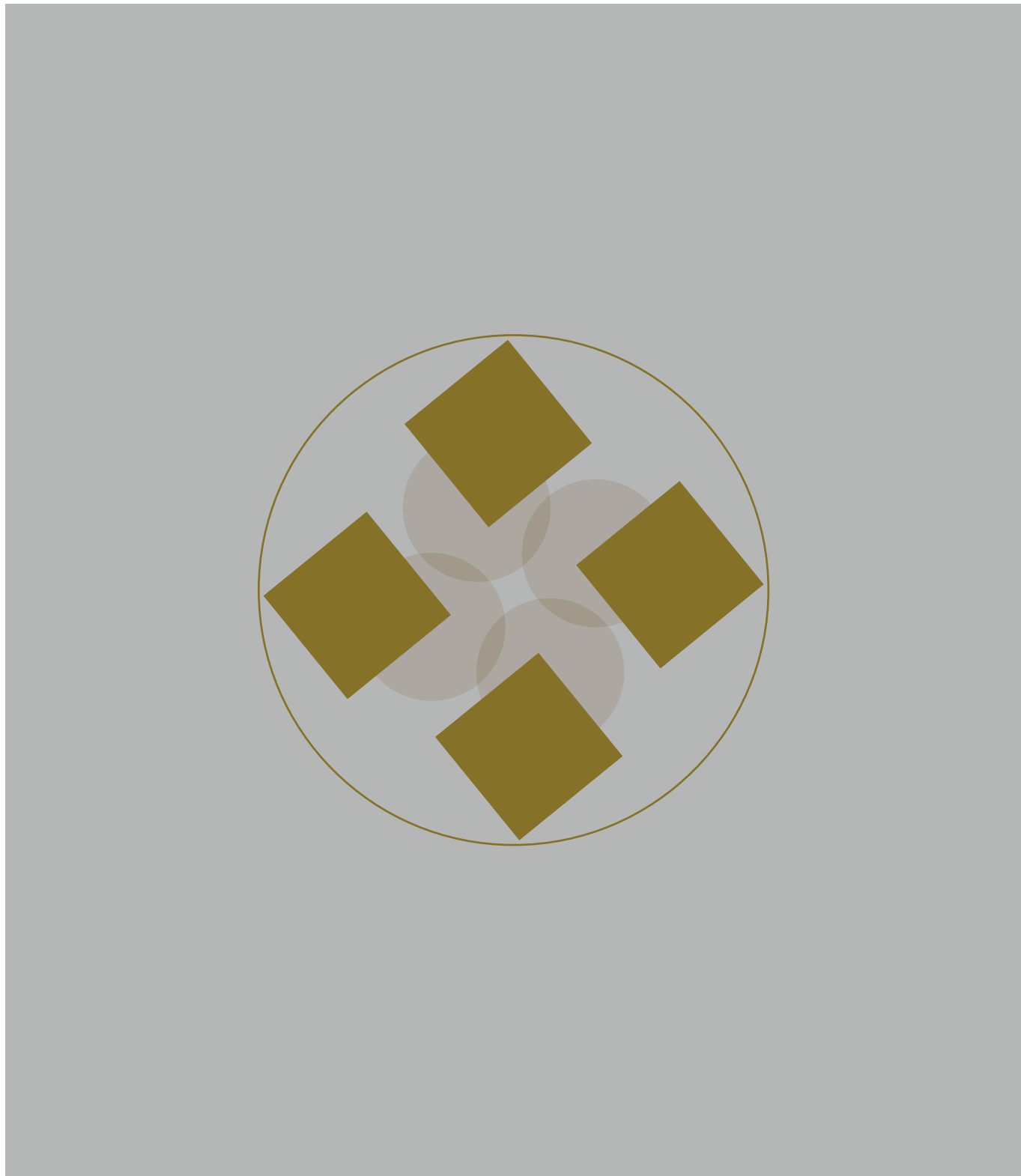
「눈치」, 2026
Composition — Rapidly increasing
English Approximation — Choked Up,
Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
positive and negative)

내숭
Playing Coy, Pretense

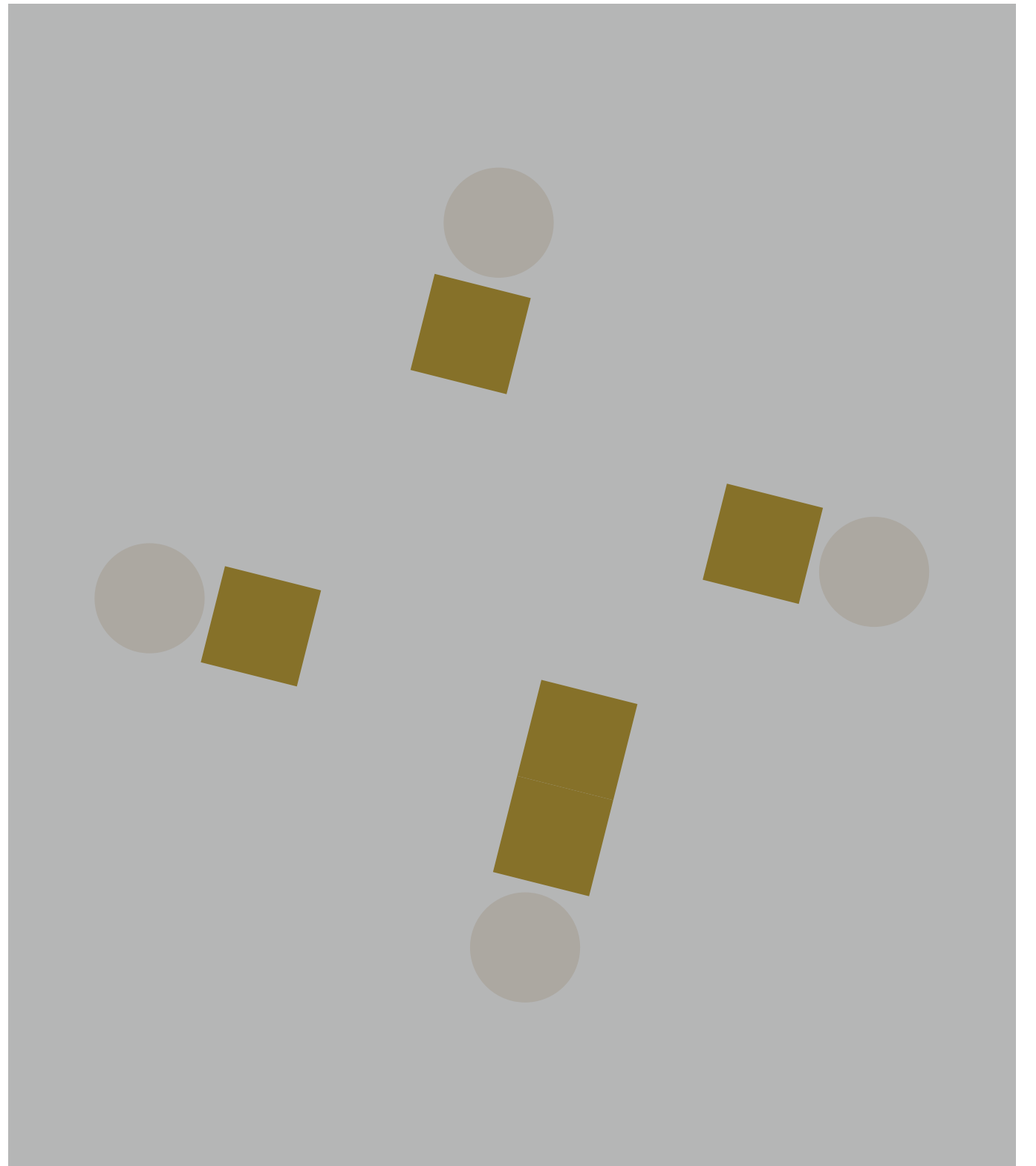
1
English Approximation — Playing Coy,
Pretense

2
Definitione — The act of concealing one's
true feelings, desires, or nature behind
a façade of innocence or indifference —
pretending not to want what one clearly
wants, or feigning modesty to appear more
proper or refined.

2
Contextual Usage — She had been talking
about that bag for weeks, yet when it was
gifted to her, she waved it off with "oh, you
didn't have to." "Don't be such naesung —
everyone already knows how much you
wanted it."



「내숭」, 2026
 Composition — Rapidly increasing
 English Approximation — Choked Up,
 Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
 positive and negative)



「내숭」, 2026
 Composition — Rapidly increasing
 English Approximation — Choked Up,
 Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
 positive and negative)



「내승」, 2026
 Composition — Rapidly increasing
 English Approximation — Choked Up,
 Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
 positive and negative)

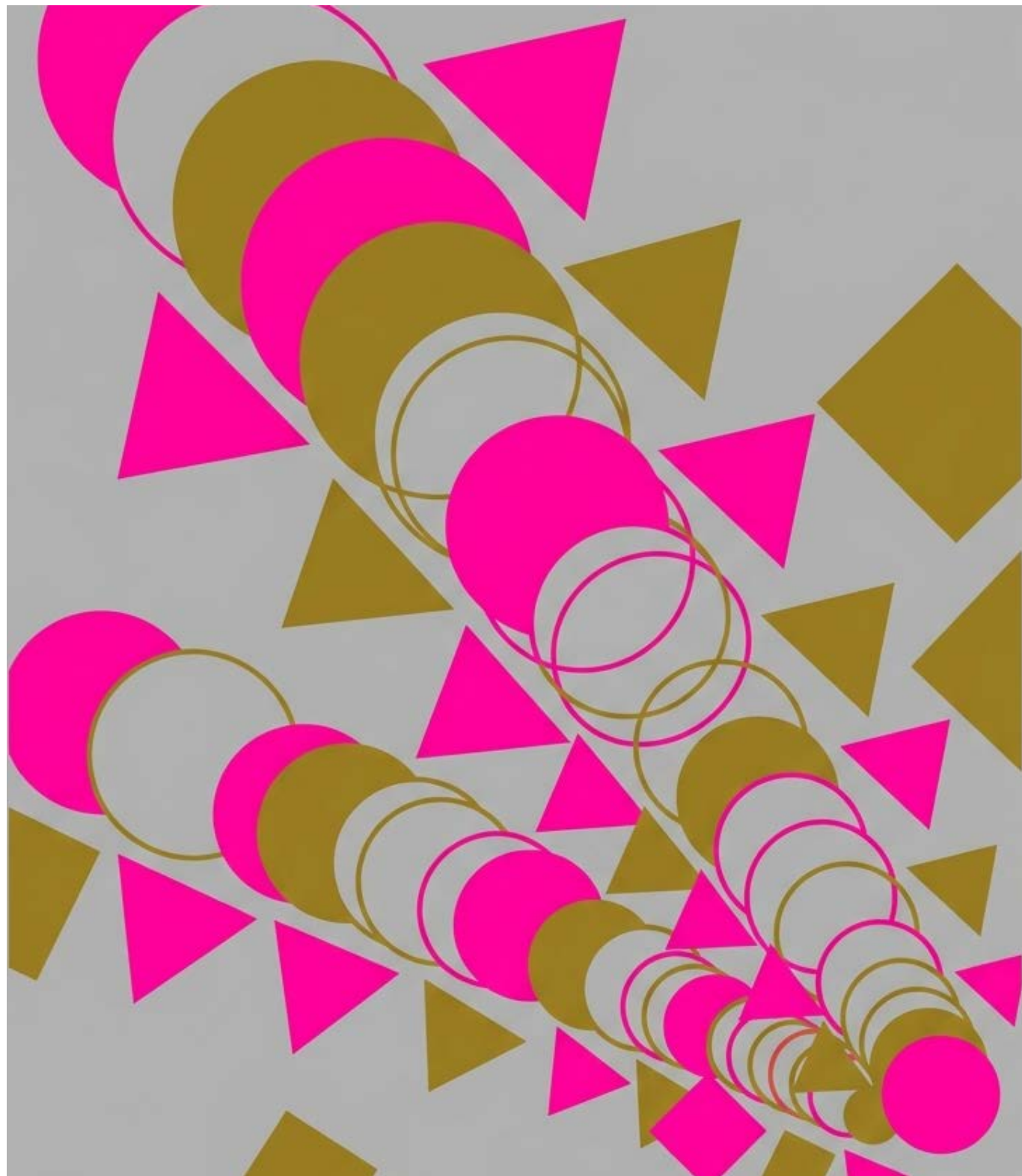
「내승」, 2026
 Composition — Rapidly increasing
 English Approximation — Choked Up,
 Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
 positive and negative)

빨리빨리
Hurry, Quickly

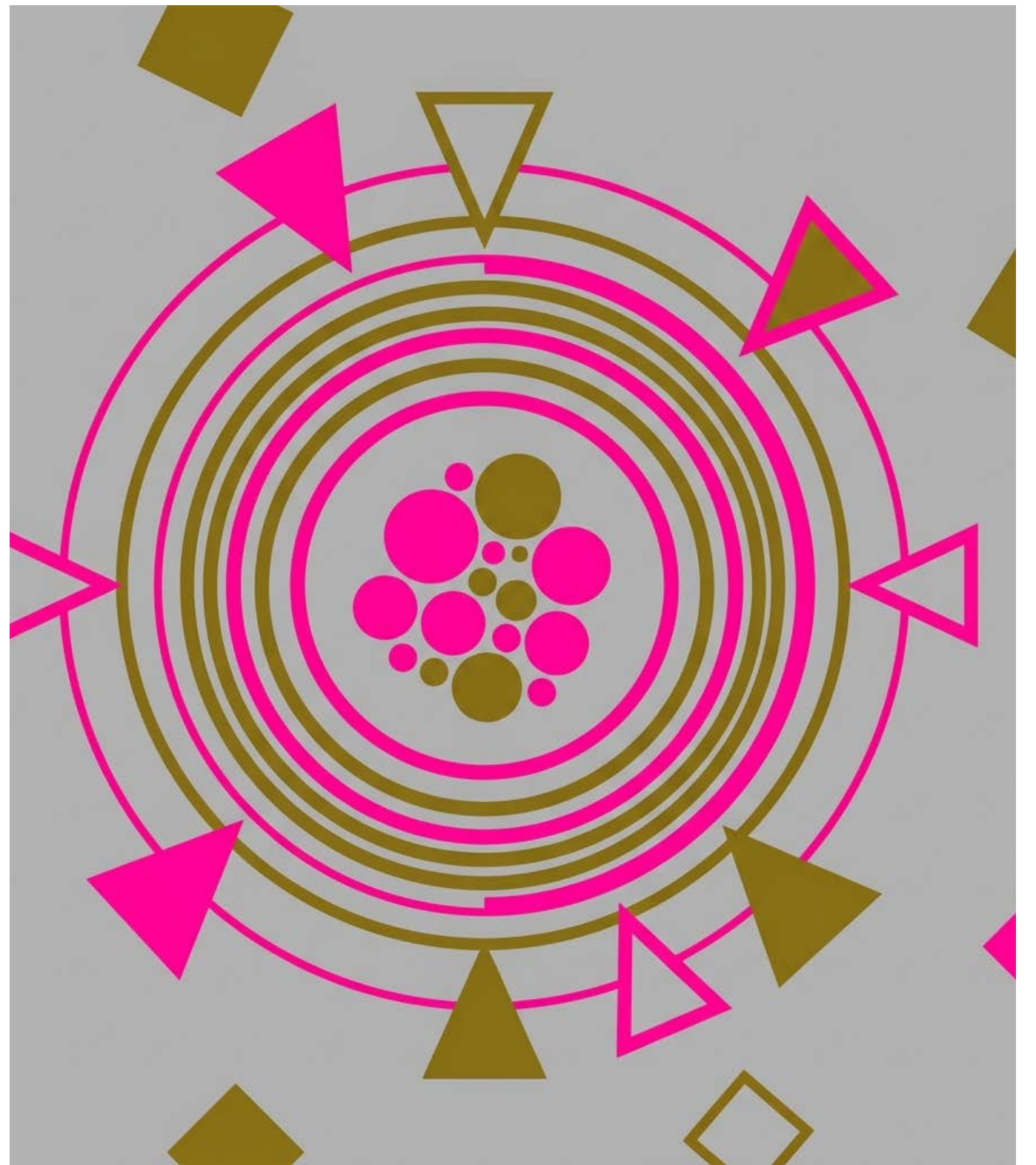
1
English Approximation — Playing Coy,
Pretense

2
Definitione — The act of concealing one's
true feelings, desires, or nature behind
a façade of innocence or indifference —
pretending not to want what one clearly
wants, or feigning modesty to appear more
proper or refined.

2
Contextual Usage — She had been talking
about that bag for weeks, yet when it was
gifted to her, she waved it off with "oh, you
didn't have to." "Don't be such naesung —
everyone already knows how much you
wanted it."



『빨리빨리』, 2026
Composition — Rapidly increasing
English Approximation — Choked Up,
Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
positive and negative)



『빨리빨리』, 2026
Composition — Rapidly increasing
English Approximation — Choked Up,
Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
positive and negative)



『빨리빨리』, 2026

Composition — Rapidly increasing
English Approximation — Choked Up,
Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
positive and negative)

『빨리빨리』, 2026

Composition — Rapidly increasing
English Approximation — Choked Up,
Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
positive and negative)

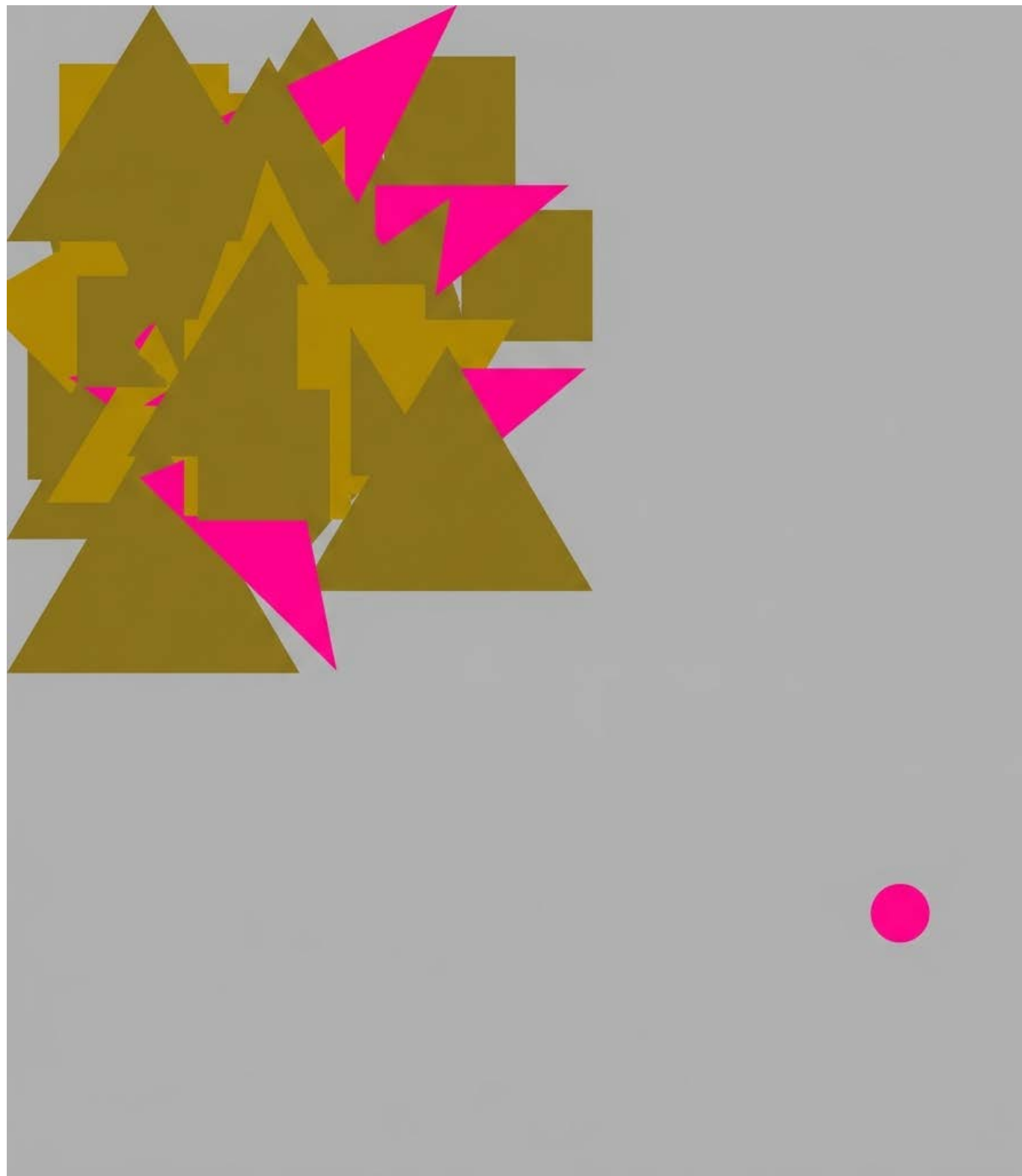
삽질

Wasted Effort, Yak Shaving — Yak Shaving

1
English Approximation — Playing Coy, Pretense

2
Definitione — The act of concealing one's true feelings, desires, or nature behind a façade of innocence or indifference — pretending not to want what one clearly wants, or feigning modesty to appear more proper or refined.

2
Contextual Usage — She had been talking about that bag for weeks, yet when it was gifted to her, she waved it off with "oh, you didn't have to." "Don't be such naesung — everyone already knows how much you wanted it."



「삼질」, 2026
 Composition — Rapidly increasing
 English Approximation — Choked Up,
 Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
 positive and negative)



「삼질」, 2026
 Composition — Rapidly increasing
 English Approximation — Choked Up,
 Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
 positive and negative)



「삼질」, 2026
 Composition — Rapidly increasing
 English Approximation — Choked Up,
 Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
 positive and negative)

「삼질」, 2026
 Composition — Rapidly increasing
 English Approximation — Choked Up,
 Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
 positive and negative)

팔자

Fate, Lot In Life — Lot In Life

1

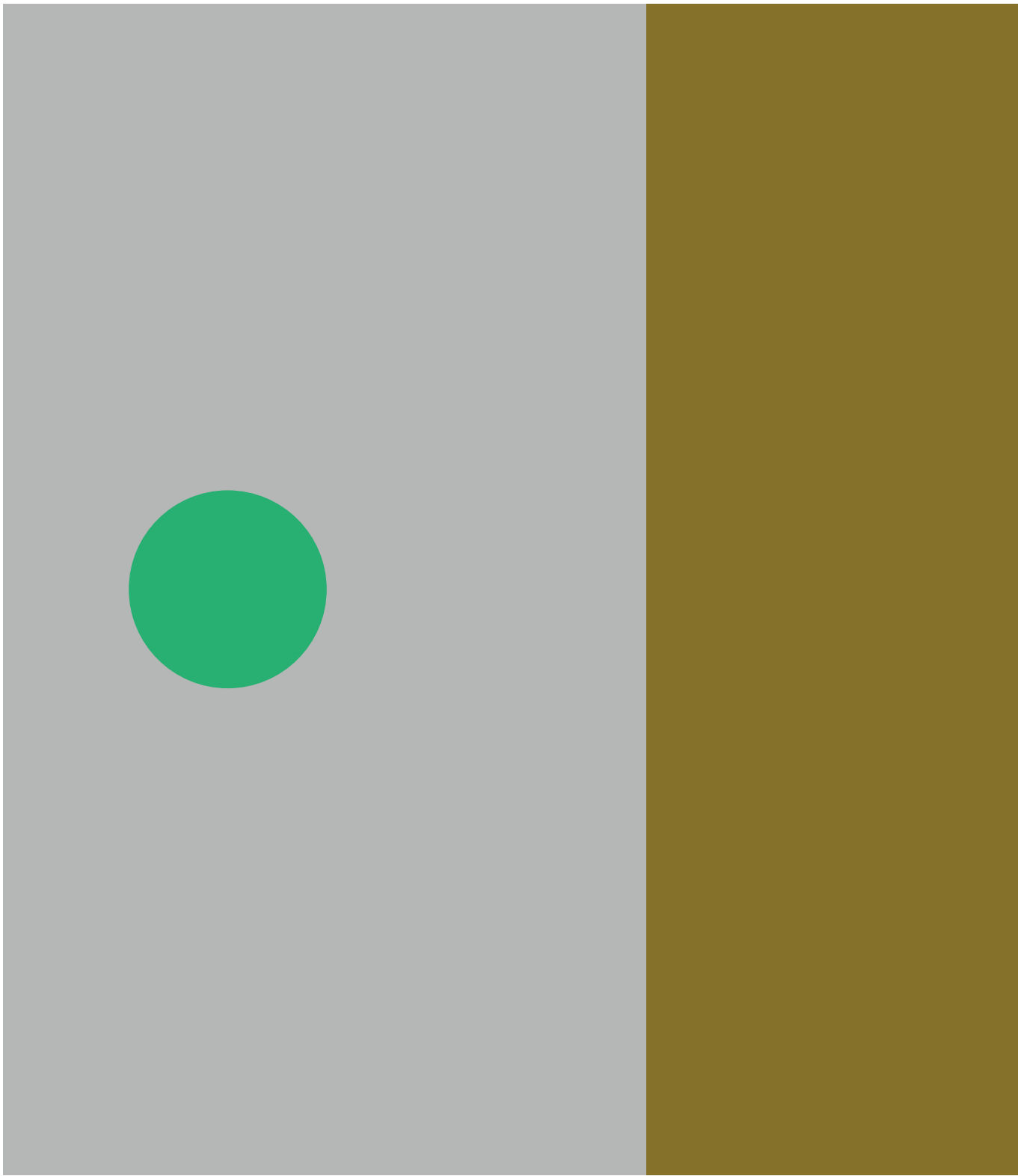
English Approximation — Playing Coy, Pretense

2

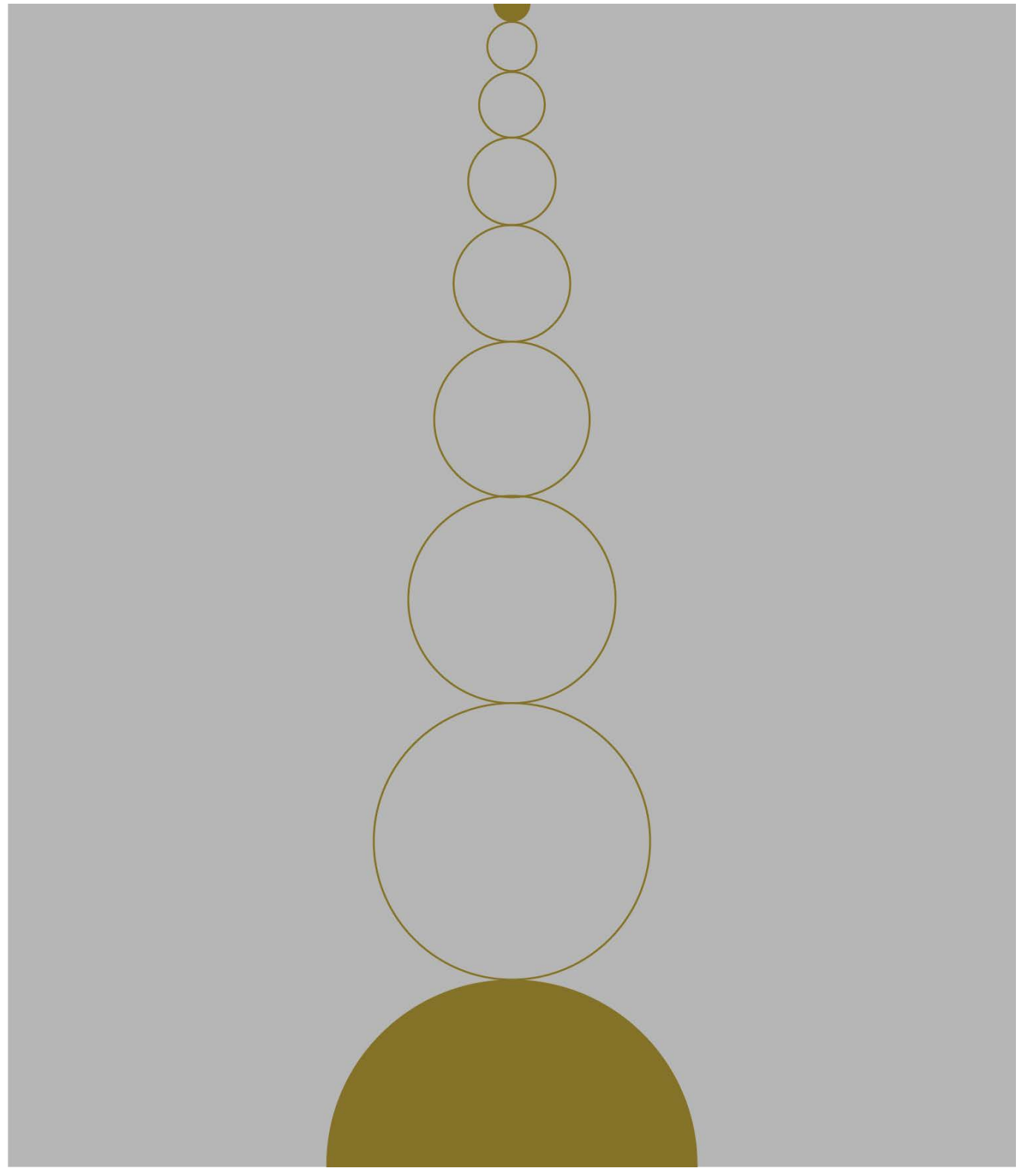
Definitione — The act of concealing one's true feelings, desires, or nature behind a façade of innocence or indifference — pretending not to want what one clearly wants, or feigning modesty to appear more proper or refined.

2

Contextual Usage — She had been talking about that bag for weeks, yet when it was gifted to her, she waved it off with "oh, you didn't have to." "Don't be such naesung — everyone already knows how much you wanted it."



「팔자」, 2026
Composition — Rapidly increasing
English Approximation — Choked Up,
Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
positive and negative)



「팔자」, 2026
Composition — Rapidly increasing
English Approximation — Choked Up,
Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
positive and negative)



『팔자』, 2026
Composition — Rapidly increasing
English Approximation — Choked Up,
Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
positive and negative)

『팔자』, 2026
Composition — Rapidly increasing
English Approximation — Choked Up,
Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
positive and negative)

반말

Casual speech, Informal Language

1

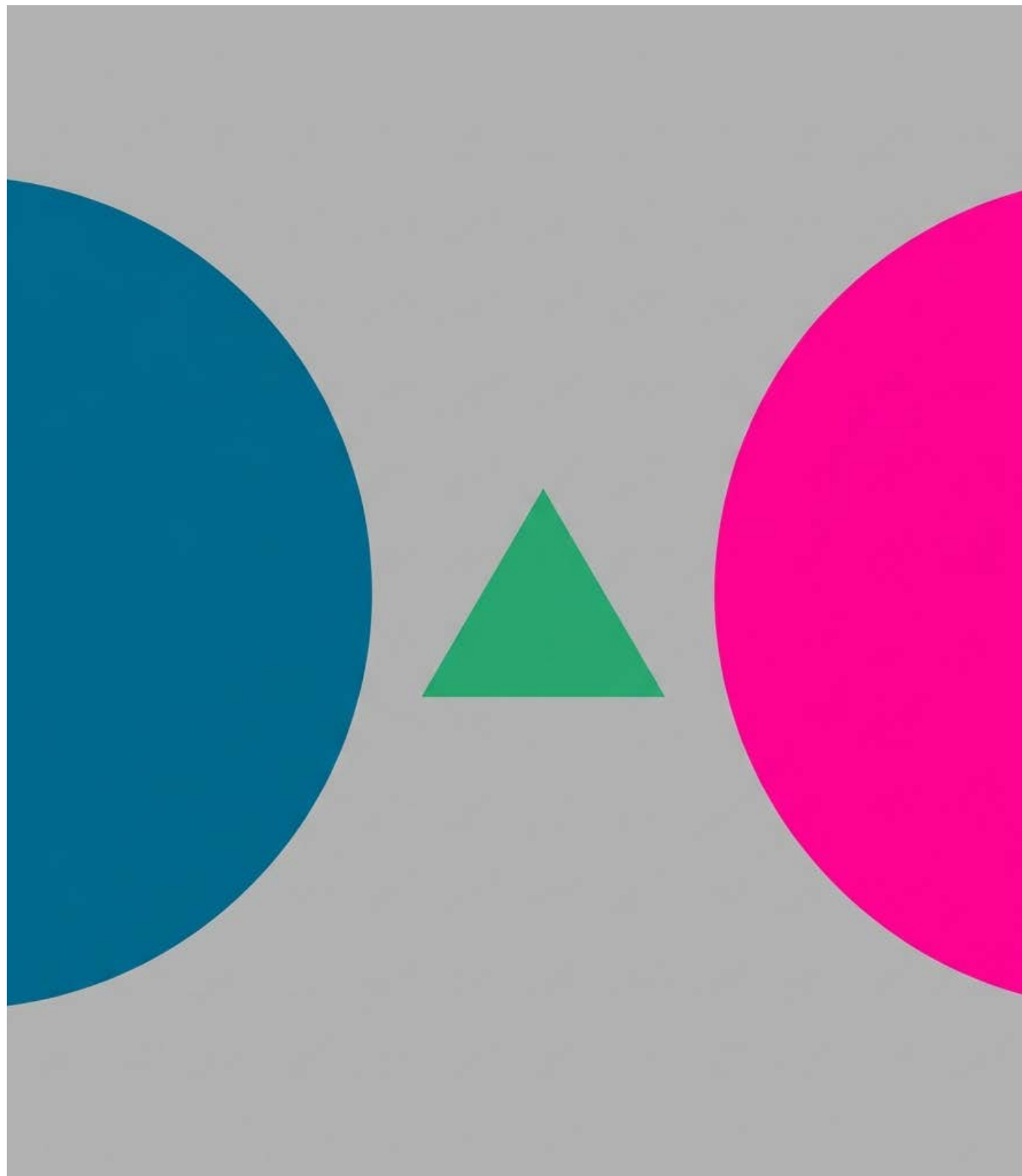
English Approximation — Playing Coy, Pretense

2

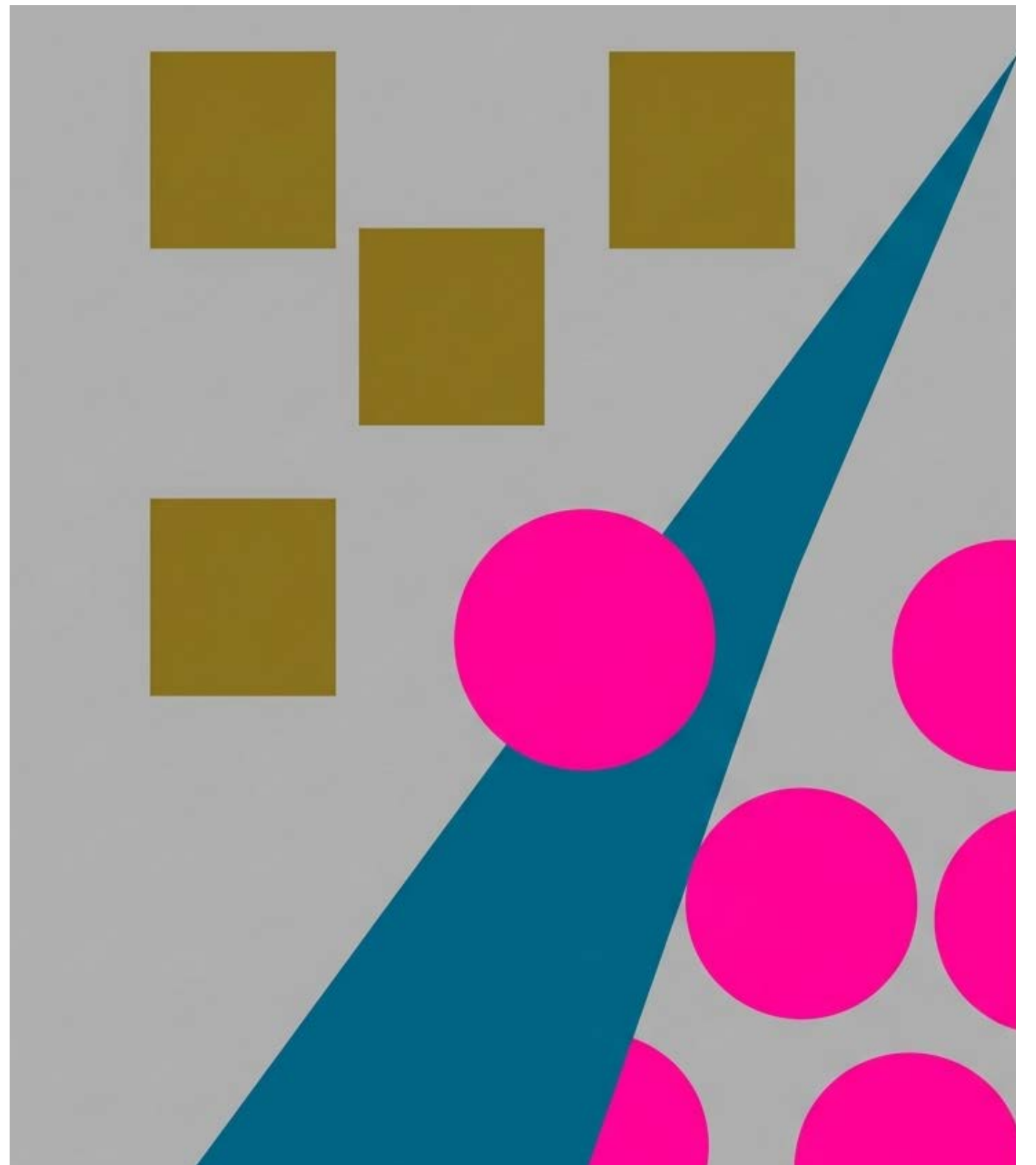
Definitione — The act of concealing one's true feelings, desires, or nature behind a façade of innocence or indifference — pretending not to want what one clearly wants, or feigning modesty to appear more proper or refined.

2

Contextual Usage — She had been talking about that bag for weeks, yet when it was gifted to her, she waved it off with "oh, you didn't have to." "Don't be such naesung — everyone already knows how much you wanted it."



『반말』, 2026
 Composition — Rapidly increasing
 English Approximation — Choked Up,
 Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
 positive and negative)



『반말』, 2026
 Composition — Rapidly increasing
 English Approximation — Choked Up,
 Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
 positive and negative)



『반말』, 2026

Composition — Rapidly increasing
English Approximation — Choked Up,
Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
positive and negative)

『반말』, 2026

Composition — Rapidly increasing
English Approximation — Choked Up,
Welling Up(Volatile, Equivoca Both of
positive and negative)

